

6.1a

An introduction to report writing

Worksheet

A Read the example report below. When you finish, read the report a second time and decide whether the author thinks statements 1–5 are True or False.

- 1 When revising your report you should keep the same headings and sections. T/F
- 2 It is better to try to write grammatically correct sentences right from the start. T/F
- 3 Reports are usually full of long phrases and complex grammatical structures. T/F
- 4 Your writing style will depend partly on who will read the report. T/F
- 5 The passive emphasizes the action rather than who does the action. T/F

Writing Business Reports

1 Introduction

This short report summarizes the topic of writing business reports. It discusses the importance of organizing the report into logical sections. It recommends some techniques for writing clearly and also considers some important grammatical areas. The report emphasizes that planning and then rewriting several times is the key to successful report writing.

2 Structure of a report

The report you are now reading is typical of a short report: first an introduction that describes the purpose and structure of the report, then the body of the report, and finally some recommendations or conclusions. Longer reports may have other sections such as a summary, table of contents or perhaps appendices with extra, non-essential information. Many in-company reports have a standard format and so the writer does not have to worry about the structure.

3 Sections and paragraphs

Reports are often about complex issues, so the writer has to organize the material very clearly into logical sections and sub-sections with appropriate headings. Deciding how to do this is probably the most important step in report writing. Of course as you write you may move information around and change your headings.

Within each section the material is divided into paragraphs. Short paragraphs help the reader to see the structure of the argument and understand the information. A simple rule is: one main idea, one paragraph.

4 The techniques of report writing

- Focus initially on the ideas, not the language and grammar. Leave the language until the editing and rewriting stage. (Each version you write is called a draft).
- Use short phrases. Keep sentences brief and use simple grammatical structures.
- Use an impersonal style. Focus on facts and only name individuals when it is relevant.
- Present your points in a balanced way that shows you have considered the arguments carefully.
- Keep the reader in mind. For example, a report written for a senior manager might be respectful and polite; with suggestions for the manager to consider. A report for junior staff is more likely to use a direct style and have short sentences and statements rather than suggestions.

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